



SHOT IN THE ARM: Raj's arrest is likely to boost his popularity

NO JAIL ONLY BAIL

After a week's inaction the state Government arrests Raj Thackeray for his provocative remarks only for him to be released on bail hours later, turning a week's high voltage drama into a farce

■ **By Aditi Pai**

It's not very often that the Congress and the BJP talk the same language. In a week in which Raj Thackeray, estranged nephew of Shiv Sena chief Bal Thackeray and wannabe leader told Mumbai's millions of north Indians that the city did not belong to them, leaders of both national parties, their differences notwithstanding, spoke as one and demanded that the self-styled president of the Maharashtra Navnirman Samiti (MNS) be arrested. It finally happened on February 13, eight days after Raj was booked under several sections of the Indian Penal Code



Azmi

LIVEPHOTO

for offences that could get him up to three years in jail. Also in the dock was Samajwadi Party's (SP) Mumbai President Abu Asim Azmi, with whom Raj had been having a war of words for sometime. A few hours later, Raj was released on a bail bond of Rs 15,000, while Azmi got away with Rs 10,000.

As with elections in many states in recent times, in public posturing too the two big national parties were upstaged by the smaller but regionally powerful local ones. The Congress and the BJP addressed pan-Indian concerns by claiming Mumbai for all Indians while regional parties like the NCP, Shiv Sena and others—either through their silence, inaction or tacit support—addressed the concerns of the locals. It's almost as if Raj wanted to be arrested so that the glare of tv cameras would continue to be on him. Thanks to his absurd political postur-

Mumbai was agog with talk that the Raj-Azmi skirmish was aimed at reviving their flagging political careers.